

Chapter 72-1

It was currently rush hour. On the asphalt road, traffic flowed like water, and the chaotic red tail lights reminded people that night was falling.

Along the roadside were office workers coming and going, gathering in groups of three to five, chatting and laughing as they walked toward the nearby subway station.

Xu Qingzhu's long hair was blown by the wind. She wore five-centimeter heels, revealing her fair ankles. Black pencil pants wrapped around her calves, slender and straight. Her body proportions were enviably superior.

Liang Shi stood beside her in a light gray trench coat, paired with a white shirt and black pants—all minimalist attire.

Liang Shi was 1.72 meters tall, six centimeters taller than Xu Qingzhu in bare feet. However, she would change back into flat shoes when driving after work, so standing beside Xu Qingzhu now, visually the two appeared about the same height.

Both equally tall and slender, both with excellent body proportions.

Liang Shi walked slightly ahead of Xu Qingzhu, attempting to shield her from something.

Su Meiqi suddenly grabbed Zhou Yi'an's sleeve tightly. "Sister An, these two look so good together!"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

Quite an eyesore.

Su Meiqi's eyes sparkled brightly. She rushed over first and called out to Xu Qingzhu, "Sister Xu."

Then she greeted Liang Shi, "Sister Liang."

Last time after coming down from Yunfeng Mountain¹, Su Meiqi had naturally become familiar with the two of them in the car.

Now meeting them again, she was still as naturally friendly.

"What a coincidence." Su Meiqi said, "What are you two going to do? On a date?"

"Mm." Liang Shi answered first: "Planning to go eat."

"Us too." Su Meiqi said, "To celebrate me finding a job, my aunt is treating us to dinner."

"That is quite a coincidence." Xu Qingzhu's expression was cold, but her gaze fell on Su Yao.

Su Yao wore sunglasses, stood elegantly with a slender neck, and her naturally black hair made her skin appear fair.

There was no indication at all that this was a woman in her early forties.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought of a phrase: Time never defeats a beauty.

Because Sheng Yu tilted her head first and said, "It's Rainbow's mommy's colleague."

Su Yao then looked toward Liang Shi. She smiled and nodded, "What a coincidence, we meet again."

"Mm." Liang Shi maintained a polite yet distant demeanor throughout, "Hello."

Little bean² Sheng Yu, as if afraid of being ignored, tried her best to assert her presence. Looking up, she asked Liang Shi, "Auntie, do you work here?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Suddenly felt like her knee had taken an arrow³.

But she couldn't say anything, so she could only answer: "My wife is here."

"Wow." Sheng Yu's eyes turned into hearts, "This sister is so beautiful."

Liang Shi: "?"

Are you being polite?

Liang Shi's expression changed slightly, but she didn't quibble with a five-year-old child over the form of address. Instead, she said ambiguously, "You'll be this beautiful when you grow up too."

Following Sheng Yu's words, Su Yao finally turned her gaze to Xu Qingzhu.

More accurately, they locked eyes.

A few seconds later, tears slid down Su Yao's face.

Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly. She pressed her lips together and looked at Su Yao, asking with a somewhat sharp momentum, "Do you know me?"

Su Yao was dazed. She shook her head extremely slowly, like a body that had been stiff for a long time just starting to move.

"Then you....." Xu Qingzhu had just started her sentence, her belly full of aggressive questions not yet spoken, when she saw Su Yao open and close her mouth, trying to speak several times but unable to, while two clear tears slid down her face.

Su Meiqi panicked and immediately searched for tissues in her bag, asking in a low voice, "Auntie, what's wrong?"

Only then did Su Yao realize she had shed tears. She immediately raised her hand to wipe them, and in her panic knocked off her sunglasses, revealing one lifeless eye, while the other eye was red-rimmed and brimming with tears.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. Her hand resting on Liang Shi's gripped tighter, as if drawing strength from her.

After Su Yao wiped away her tears and put her sunglasses back on, she apologized in a gentle voice, "Miss, I'm sorry, I... lost my composure."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu paused, "May I ask, if you don't know me, why did you show me such an expression? This creates misunderstanding."

Su Yao shook her head, "I don't know."

Her voice was muffled, hoarse from sobbing, "I have no idea what happened."

In fact, when she saw this young lady before her, her mind went completely blank.

It was as if some natural emotion was driving her tear glands, making her cry inexplicably. Even after she came to her senses, she didn't know what she was doing.

This question—she wanted to ask it herself.

But Su Yao could only shake her head, "I truly apologize."

Her tone was sincere and carried guilt, making it hard for anyone to give her a hard time.

But Xu Qingzhu had already walked over and taken the first step, so naturally there was no reason to retreat.

She showed a reasonably appropriate smile, "Is it because you've seen me before?"

"No." After facing her, Su Yao seemed somewhat wooden, only shaking her head lightly: "I don't think I've ever seen you."

"But you give me a very familiar feeling." Su Yao looked at her features and pressed her lips together, "You look somewhat like my husband."

"Your husband?" Xu Qingzhu's tone rose, "Is he this little friend's father?"

"Yes." Su Yao said, "He passed away."

Footnotes:

¹ Yunfeng Mountain: A location referenced in previous chapters where these characters had an encounter.

² Little bean (小豆丁): A Chinese term of endearment for small children, literally "little bean," used to describe someone who is small and cute.

³ Took an arrow to the knee: An expression meaning to feel hurt or attacked. Liang Shi feels this way because Sheng Yu called her "auntie" instead of "sister" (which would imply she looks younger), then immediately called Xu Qingzhu the more youthful-sounding "sister."

Chapter 72-2

When facing Liang Shi, Su Yao was very guarded. Previously when Liang Shi inquired about her related information, Su Yao refused to reveal even one more sentence.

But now facing Xu Qingzhu, she very naturally disclosed her own information.

And it was very private information.

"Then may I ask, do you and your husband only have this one daughter?" Xu Qingzhu still smiled.

But that smile carried coldness, indifference, and a trace of barely perceptible nervousness.

"Enough." Zhou Yi'an, standing to the side, couldn't help but speak up, her voice sharp: "Why is President Xu so concerned about other people's family matters? Didn't you say you didn't want to know?"

"I suddenly want to know now." Xu Qingzhu said, "Rather than having others tell me, I'd prefer to ask myself."

Xu Qingzhu locked eyes with her, her dark pupils appearing earnest and tenacious.

She was speaking in riddles with Zhou Yi'an in broad daylight.

Zhou Yi'an said coldly, "Then why not ask me."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, spine straight, lips curved in a light smile, "Why would I ask you about my own matters?"

Just one sentence was enough to make Zhou Yi'an back down.

But Su Yao said gently, "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

Su Meiqi also nodded frantically, "Auntie, I don't understand either."

Sheng Yu jumped up and raised her hand, "Me, me, me! I don't understand either."

Xu Qingzhu's voice was clear and cold as she only asked her: "So do you only have this one daughter?"

Su Yao once again showed that confused expression. The large sunglasses covered most of her face, but one could still tell from her stiff body movements.

For a long while, the people on both sides of the road gradually dispersed. Street lights lit up one after another as the entire city entered nighttime.

Su Yao's tone was regretful and helpless.

She said, "I don't remember."

"You've lost your memory?" Xu Qingzhu asked again, "May I ask how far back your memory can trace? Is it ten years ago, or twenty years ago? Or, do you still remember someone called....."

As she was saying this, Su Yao proactively removed her sunglasses.

Su Yao's left eye was hollow and lifeless, while her right eyeball turned, looking forlorn and sorrowful. Her complexion was much paler than before, her spirit seeming ready to collapse, yet even so, she was still trying hard to listen, to hear what this young lady across from her was saying.

Su Yao herself didn't know what was wrong with her.

It was just a very strange feeling.

Even though this young lady across from her seemed to have hostility toward her, speaking aggressively with an extremely cold tone, she just wanted to hear clearly what the other party was saying, wanted to know what the other party was thinking, and wanted to be close to the other party.

So she proactively removed her sunglasses, wanting to see more of the other party's face.

Could it be because of the facial features that were extremely similar to Qinglin's?

Especially those eyes.

The other party was currently in a state of high tension, so her dark pupils appeared earnest and stubborn.

She remembered many years ago, when she and Sheng Qinglin had an argument over an issue, Sheng Qinglin was exactly like this.

Previously, she had already accepted the impact that amnesia had brought to her life.

From a certain perspective, amnesia made her remaining memories more vivid.

Those fragments preserved in her memory, of getting along with Sheng Qinglin, traces of their love, seemed like they had happened just yesterday.

But recently, somehow, she kept having dreams late at night.

In her dreams, a voice would ask her: "Why did you forget me? Why? Aren't you supposed to love me very much?"

It was a childish voice, and then by her ear would sound an infant's crying, just like when she had first given birth to Sheng Yu.

So after waking up, she would be doubly good to Sheng Yu.

She had also asked Su Zhe if she had forgotten someone very important.

Su Zhe's answer was: "No more, all your most important people are by your side now."

But when the other party locked eyes with her, she suddenly paused, even her breathing seemed to have the pause button pressed.

"Who?" Su Yao continued her words with a question, even with encouragement.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. In the end, she still hardened her heart, pronouncing that name almost word by word: "Sheng. Qing. Lin."

Su Yao was astonished, then laughed, mixed with some bitterness, "He was my husband. Do you know him?"

After saying this, she negated it herself, "My husband passed away many years ago. Miss, you should be... quite young? How old are you this year?"

"Twenty-three." Xu Qingzhu said coldly.

Su Yao paused, saying in a daze, "My husband also passed away twenty-three years ago."

Xu Qingzhu tried to see traces of lying on her face, but she just had a wooden expression, a sincere tone, answering almost any question she asked.

And with a naturally indulgent and doting tone.

Even when calling her "Miss," it was done cautiously.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, then introduced herself: "Hello, my name is Xu Qingzhu."

Su Yao's expression stiffened. Tears involuntarily fell again. She shook her head woodenly, her movements extremely slow. Her whole person appeared very confused, as if searching for something.

Xu Qingzhu's cold voice carried a hint of choking, no longer as sharp as before.

She said, "Sheng Qinglin is my uncle."

Chapter 72-3

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The scene downstairs at the company ended unpleasantly.

Su Yao's complexion was too pale, her entire person in a state of mental wandering. Her hands gripped her clothes tightly, wanting to say something to Xu Qingzhu but unable to speak.

It was the state of a patient on the verge of collapse.

So Zhou Yi'an said sternly, "Enough."

Su Meiqi also supported Su Yao, looking at Xu Qingzhu with slight reproach: "Sister Xu, what are you saying?"

She wanted to take Su Yao to the car, but Su Yao just wouldn't move.

Sheng Yu stood there looking left and right, then finally walked over and pushed Xu Qingzhu. Fortunately, Liang Shi was supporting her, otherwise she would have been pushed to the ground by this child's sudden movement.

Sheng Yu glared at Xu Qingzhu with aggrieved eyes, "You bad person! Bullying my mommy!"

Liang Shi blocked Xu Qingzhu's front and grabbed Sheng Yu's hand, about to discipline her when Su Yao staggered over, crouched down halfway to protect Sheng Yu, soothing in a low voice: "Mommy is fine....."

Before Sheng Yu could cry, Su Yao pulled her and said, "Apologize to this sister."

Sheng Yu turned her head away stubbornly, "No!"

After another round of wrangling, Xu Qingzhu felt mentally exhausted. She tugged at Liang Shi's wrist and said in a low voice, "Let's go."

Just as she and Liang Shi were about to leave, Su Yao suddenly called out loudly: "Miss Xu."

Xu Qingzhu half-turned, glancing sideways, "Mm?"

"Will we see each other again in the future?" Su Yao asked.

With some humble caution.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment and answered ambiguously: "Maybe."

This episode caused Xu Qingzhu's mood to plummet. Liang Shi drove away from that office building, that street. The figures of Su Yao and the others gradually blurred into points of light and disappeared from view.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the passenger seat, closing her eyes to rest for a while.

Liang Shi thought she was sad and appropriately played some instrumental music.

Halfway through the instrumental piece, while waiting at a red light, Liang Shi consoled gently: "Xu Qingzhu, if you're unhappy, just say it. I can listen."

"I'm not unhappy." Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes. Those eyes were as cold and sharp as usual, even her voice had returned to its normal state, "I'm just thinking about what exactly happened back then."

Liang Shi: "?"

She was taken aback, "You're really not sad?"

Xu Qingzhu calmly asked back, "Would being sad help?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Right, it wouldn't help.

Or perhaps Xu Qingzhu had already passed that time of sadness. When she initially couldn't accept the truth, she would avoid it and feel upset.

But once she accepted it, she would rapidly enter the right state of mind.

Liang Shi didn't beat around the bush either, asking directly: "So, are you planning to acknowledge the relationship?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Not planning to at the moment."

"I need to investigate what happened over twenty years ago." Xu Qingzhu said, "But I'm hesitating about whether or not to investigate."

Once she investigated, it would inevitably uncover some ugly things.

Liang Shi hadn't expected that Xu Qingzhu's thinking had already progressed to this step.

As if she had boarded a rocket—absurdly fast.

Chapter 72-4

"How can you be certain that something must have happened over twenty years ago?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused. Her clear, cold voice sounded simultaneously with the car engine starting, but completely overpowered the sound of the car.

The car sped along the road. Xu Qingzhu's speech was neither hurried nor slow as she analyzed methodically: "I just saw her. Obviously, she doesn't remember having had another daughter, and even Su Meiqi doesn't know."

"Zhou Yi'an told me that sentence about her always being in a psychiatric hospital, which indirectly indicates she might have developed mental illness from strong external stimulation. But she would take that little child to visit my uncle." When Xu Qingzhu said this term of address, she suddenly paused. After a while, she continued, "And you told me that little child is from a single-parent family, and her surname is Sheng, so it's very likely she's her and my uncle's daughter."

"Your uncle passed away many years ago." Liang Shi said.

"Sperm can be frozen." Xu Qingzhu said, "Su Yao still remembers things related to him, so this wouldn't be very difficult to accomplish."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had actually forgotten about that option.

And Xu Qingzhu continued analyzing, "The current CEO of Haiwei Jewelry is her older brother. Recently, while organizing Minghui's old materials, I discovered that Haiwei Jewelry has been in competition with Minghui in many areas, mainly starting from fifteen years ago. At that time, Su Zhe assumed the CEO position and repeatedly stole Minghui's business, ultimately dividing up the market directly."

"Couldn't it just be normal business competition?" Liang Shi deliberately asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "If it were normal business competition, then Haiwei should treat all companies in the jewelry industry equally. But very conveniently, he only targeted Minghui, even engaging in predatory pricing within the industry to steal resources from Minghui. It's purely squeezing out Minghui."

Liang Shi: "....."

I see.

"As recently as July this year, Haiwei was still squeezing Minghui's survival space, but ever since I entered the company....." Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, "Haiwei loosened its grip on Minghui. Even the competitive relationship isn't as obvious anymore, and they've even intentionally or unintentionally helped once."

"Although I'm not too certain about this point—after all, I've only been at the company for a short time—what I can confirm is that Su Zhe went crazy suppressing Minghui after taking his position, which should be related to his younger sister. And he knows about these matters, so why didn't he come to the Sheng family to demand an explanation? Why does he keep suppressing them in the business world instead?" Xu Qingzhu raised several questions in succession, then answered them herself: "It means they had a conflict over Sheng Qinglin's death over twenty years ago, and it should have been a very big conflict."

Liang Shi: "....."

This logical reasoning ability was truly exceptional.

But that wasn't all. Xu Qingzhu continued earnestly: "My birthday is forty days before Sheng Qinglin's death anniversary. The year I was born and the year he died are the same. If all of this is just coincidence..... then I can only say that things in this world are absurdly, ridiculously coincidental."

Liang Shi: "....."

After a long silence in the car, Liang Shi said quietly: "Don't you think your reasoning ability is absurdly strong?"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She was still seriously thinking about the whole matter, then looked at Liang Shi with astonishment, "Is this difficult?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"It requires remembering every detail and stringing them together." Liang Shi affirmed, "It's actually very difficult."

Xu Qingzhu: "..... Not too bad."

"So are you really going to dig up the truth?" Liang Shi asked, "The truth might be very cruel."

If it weren't cruel, Su Yao wouldn't have lost her memory, and wouldn't have lived like a mental patient for so many years.

This was a very realistic matter.

"But I also have the right to know." Xu Qingzhu propped one hand against the car window, her head resting in her palm. She looked lazy and casual, no longer tense like before, "Mainly because I feel that even if I don't want to know, someone will chase after me to tell me, so I might as well go look for myself."

"You mean Zhou Yi'an?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Not just her."

After she entered the company, she would encounter Su Zhe sooner or later.

Then there was Zhou Yi'an, Su Meiqi, and even when Liang Shi went to pick up a child, she would run into Sheng Yu.

It was as if there was an invisible thread connecting all these people.

Suddenly, silently entering her life, as if wordlessly saying: "You should know."

Then she would know.

Xu Qingzhu had adjusted her state and prepared herself mentally for the worst.

Liang Shi couldn't help but admire her psychological fortitude, saying sincerely: "Teacher Xu, you're amazing."

Without her needing to do anything, she had sorted out the entire matter's context by herself.

"Mm?" Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, smiling lightly: "Teacher Liang, that doesn't sound like a compliment."

Liang Shi: "No, it's absolutely sincere praise."

"Then I accept it." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi asked her: "Have you thought about what the worst outcome would be?"

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment and answered: "Su Yao's illness was caused by my grandparents, or even my parents. Su Zhe hates the Sheng family to the bone, wishing Minghui would go bankrupt immediately. Su Yao recovers her memory and once again goes abroad far away. Minghui....."

She paused, then said the last two words coldly: "Bank. Rupt."

Chapter 72-5

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Liang Shi thought Xu Qingzhu had acted on impulse, but unexpectedly, she had thought through the entire matter clearly.

Xu Qingzhu also said that if she hadn't prepared herself to accept the worst outcome, she wouldn't have done it.

Moreover, when Liang Shi initially thought Xu Qingzhu said she wasn't sure when she'd figure it out, she assumed it would be at least a few months, or two or three years.

But unexpectedly, in less than a week, she had figured it out.

Liang Shi felt..... she still knew too little about Xu Qingzhu.

This person could always surprise her.

Liang Shi also teased Xu Qingzhu, saying with such strong logical reasoning abilities, why not become a mystery writer, or pursue careers like lawyer or police officer? As a result, Xu Qingzhu shrugged, "I still have a huge company to inherit."

Liang Shi: "....."

She once again discovered Xu Qingzhu's cold humor ability.

However, that evening they went to eat, and Liang Shi took Xu Qingzhu to have super spicy hotpot.

Even though she herself couldn't really handle it, in order to make Xu Qingzhu feel a bit better, she was willing to sacrifice herself to accompany her wife¹.

After finishing dinner, Liang Shi contacted a real estate agent, having them show them apartments.

Late at night, the agent wore a thin down jacket, waiting at the residential complex entrance.

As the car drove over, Xu Qingzhu noticed the scenery becoming more and more familiar. When Liang Shi parked the car by the roadside, she said in surprise: "Isn't this the complex I said looked pretty good that day?"

"Yeah." Liang Shi said, "There happens to be an apartment available here, so we came to take a look."

Xu Qingzhu stood beside her. After walking a few steps, she said: "Teacher Liang is capable—quietly accomplishing big things."

Liang Shi: "....."

She smiled helplessly, "Teacher Xu is so smart, I always have to seize opportunities to show off a bit."

Xu Qingzhu nodded in approval, "Very impressive."

Liang Shi: "....."

Still didn't sound like much of a compliment.

But that wasn't important.

The agent took them to see a two-bedroom, one-living room apartment with one kitchen and one bathroom. It was on the 23rd floor. Taking the elevator up, the voice-activated lights turned on.

The apartment's layout was pretty good, just a bit small. The master bedroom plus the secondary bedroom here couldn't even compare to one bedroom at Qianshui Bay².

Liang Shi inquired: "Aren't there any larger apartments here?"

"No more." The agent said with difficulty, "Even this one just became available. The previous tenants were a young couple who lived here for several years. The room also has newly applied wallpaper—so pink and tender."

The agent kept talking to Liang Shi. Xu Qingzhu had already gone to look at the kitchen and bathroom.

After listening, Liang Shi answered: "Then let me discuss it with my wife."

The agent paused for a moment, then chuckled, "That's great."

Liang Shi was about to go find Xu Qingzhu when Xu Qingzhu also finished touring the apartment and walked over.

The agent sighed on the side: "You two have such a good relationship. Are you newlyweds?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ Sacrifice herself to accompany her wife (舍命陪君子): A Chinese idiom that literally means "risk one's life to accompany a gentleman/superior person." Here it's used humorously to indicate Liang Shi is willing to endure the spicy food she can't handle well just to make Xu Qingzhu feel better.

² Qianshui Bay (淺水灣): The name of the upscale residential area where they currently live, mentioned in previous chapters as a luxurious location.